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Indexing Guidelines for Authors and Editors

Contents

INTRODUCTION	1
<i>Doing it Yourself or Hiring a Professional Indexer</i>	1
HOW TO INDEX	2
<i>Indexing Software</i>	2
<i>Methods of Indexing</i>	2
<i>Timing</i>	2
INDEXING GUIDELINES	3
<i>Choice of Index Terms</i>	3
<i>Exclusions</i>	3
<i>Length</i>	4
<i>Subheadings</i>	4
FORMATTING	5
<i>Basic Formats</i>	5
<i>Conjunctions</i>	5
<i>Cross-references</i>	5
GENERAL STYLE POINTS	6
<i>Names</i>	6
Acronyms	6
Alphabetization	6
Numerals	6
<i>Numbering</i>	7
Elision of Numbers	7
Notes	7

Indexing Guidelines for Authors and Editors

INTRODUCTION

A good index can act as a strong selling point for a book, and will be of great help to readers; however, a poor index is frustrating for any researcher, and is damaging to the reputation of the book. Most Bloomsbury titles will include an index, so you should prepare to include one unless otherwise instructed by your editor.

Doing it Yourself or Hiring a Professional Indexer

Due to your subject knowledge as the book's author, we encourage you to compile your own index, as you are likely to have the strongest sense of the material that readers will find most helpful, and can therefore be trusted to eschew non-essential terms. However, you may prefer to assign the task to a professional, depending on your level of experience and/or the time available to you. It is also worth bearing in mind that a professional will bring an objectivity to the content and subject matter – equally, however, they may not share your opinions regarding the most useful terms to include.

If you wish to have Bloomsbury arrange to have your index prepared by a professional, please liaise with your editorial contact. (Check your contract, as there will usually be a cost involved.) You can also contract the index to a freelance indexer directly; however, please ensure they are able to meet the schedule of the book and are aware of the Bloomsbury Academic guidelines before they finalize the index manuscript. The Society of Indexers provides a list of accredited freelancers you may wish to utilize: <http://www.indexers.org.uk/>.

HOW TO INDEX

Indexing Software and Tools

Most professional indexers use specialized indexing software to undertake the mechanical aspects of indexing, such as sorting into alphabetical order, merging entries, checking that cross-references are in place, and automating layout. Such software packages include Macrex (www.macrex.com), Cindex (www.indexres.com) and SKY Index (www.sky-software.com); however, these are very expensive, so would not be recommended for the majority of authors.

No automated indexing tool available to most authors is sophisticated enough to rely upon alone. Common word-processing software packages (such as Microsoft Word) offer the functionality to generate an index of terms and names, but the result tends to be a concordance rather than a useful index. Human intervention is needed to invert personal names, decide concepts vs terms, and establish subheadings and cross-references.

Using AI tools for indexing:

Please ensure you adhere to **Bloomsbury's AI Policy for Authors and Illustrators**, which states that you may use AI tools to assist you in the preparation of index headword lists only if you have access to a private AI system (this is AI tool, application, or system deployed on infrastructure fully owned or controlled by an organisation you are part of, and which your organisation has explicitly confirmed safeguards submitted user data and does not train its algorithm on user-submitted prompts and content).

Note however that AI writing and indexing tools will lack a nuanced understanding of your work and its context, and the empathy with your readers necessary to produce an accurate, useful index. They also may introduce errors and erroneous headword entries. We recommend, if you do wish to use AI tools to help you create an index, that you do so with caution, only use the suggested headword list as a starting point, and always apply authorial oversight to any headword lists created.

Methods of Indexing

There are several methods of undertaking an index. You should follow whichever method you feel most comfortable with, but it is strongly advised that you compile the index while reading through the proofs; this will ensure that the main arguments, and therefore the most important terms for indexing, are captured.

Many indexers highlight useful terms and concepts on the page proofs, either using a hard copy or on-screen, before returning to collate and compile the index afterwards; you may alternatively find it more helpful to begin compiling the index in a separate document as you go through the proofs, particularly if you have some clear ideas of handy terms before the book goes into production. The proof PDF file can be used for searching and finding instances of a term, which can be very helpful; however, do check to ensure that the context is appropriate.

A traditional method of indexing used index cards to note instances of terms and concepts while reading through the proofs; however, with the sorting functions afforded by most word-processing packages, this is now a thoroughly outmoded practice.

Timing

Indexes can be compiled only after typeset page proofs have been produced, as this will be the earliest point at which the final page numbers will be known. Any later changes, even the addition of a sentence or move of an illustration, can shift text, and thus page numbers, from the affected pages on.

Your project manager will give you a deadline for the return of the index. Generally this will be two weeks; however, you will normally be expected to review your proofs during this time as well. If you foresee any problems with deadlines, please contact your project manager as soon as possible. If page numbers need to be updated after the index is completed, this will be handled by your project manager.

INDEXING GUIDELINES

Authors indexing their books for the first time are advised to study a variety of indexes in books on similar subjects to get a feel for structure and handling of terms.

Some books include separate indexes for certain terms, such as names and concepts. There are sometimes good reasons for this division, but usually one integrated index is sufficient. If there is more than one index, each should bear a headnote describing its content. These index types can include the following:

- Index of names
- Index of subjects
- Index of references (Biblical Studies/Theology)/Index Locorum (Classics): Normally used only for Biblical Studies, Classics and Theology titles, this is an index of passages (either biblical or from ancient sources) cited in the book. For Biblical Studies and Theology titles, it should be separated by book; for Classics titles, the Index Locorum should be separated by author, followed by work. Each different citation should be included, even if it falls within a page range cited elsewhere.

Examples: [Index Locorum]
Aetius
Plac.
4.11.4 278 n.118
5.15.2 171 n.23

[Index of References]
Genesis
1.23-9 90
1.27 87

If you wish to supply separate indexes for your book, please consult with your editorial contact first, as this may run counter to subject convention or series style. Similarly, if you are utilizing a freelancer, inform them of the need for separate indexes before work begins.

Choice of Index Terms

Ask yourself at each point: What is this chapter/paragraph actually 'about'? This keeps you from getting too bogged down in detail. Take care to distinguish between concepts or names mentioned in passing, versus those that are dealt with in more detail, in more than one sentence, or occurring in other parts of the text.

Rely on the terminology of the text. Among several ways of stating the same concept, use the predominant one. In a collection of essays or anthology, this will probably be the term used in the editor's introduction or opening chapter. Avoid the overly general and abstract, those that readers will not readily discern when they turn to the pages indicated.

Exclusions

Indexes can be unhelpfully cluttered by terms and references that are of little use to the reader. The index should be as concise as possible, and avoid unnecessary glosses and entries.

Frontmatter (table of contents, lists of illustrations, acknowledgements, preface, foreword) and endmatter (glossaries, bibliographies/reference sections) should not be indexed. Endnotes and footnotes should not be indexed unless they include significant amounts of material not included elsewhere in the text; likewise, appendices should only be indexed if these circumstances apply.

Most entries with only a single page reference will be of little use to the reader, unless they are mentioned or discussed at length on that page or are of vital significance to the argument of the book. If appropriate, they can be converted into a subheading under a related main heading (the entry for a book could be turned into a subheading of the author's main heading, for instance); however, in most instances it is more appropriate to excise them from the index manuscript.

Indexing two (or more) authors of a publication as a main entry normally only serves to clutter the index. It is often easier to use the publication title as the main entry, with the author names in parentheses (**Example:** *King John* (Lander and Tobin) 56, 89). If readers will be more familiar with the authors than the work, put the author names first, and include the publication title.

Example: Deleuze, Gilles, and Félix Guattari, *What is Philosophy* 59, 77

Do not use *ff.*, *et seq.* or *passim* in the index; individual locators are more useful to the reader.

Length

Over-long indexes can resemble concordances rather than truly useful guides to the key terms and concepts contained within the book. The index length should be sufficient to cover all useful elements; however, you should aim to include no more than 70–80 terms (headings and subheadings) per 10,000 words of the manuscript (roughly equivalent to 4–6 typeset pages per 100 typeset proof pages).

Subheadings

When a heading has accumulated more than six page references, subheadings should be made under the heading to bring out the uniqueness of the related material and to prevent readers from having to look up each page reference to find the material they wish to access. Exceptions are permissible, especially in biographies and local histories, for example, where all relevant page numbers, even if repetitious, may be of value. Similarly, when a subheading has accumulated more than six page references, consideration should be given to making that subheading into its own heading.

Keep the wording of subheadings short and focused on the most relevant concept. Avoid rewriting the relevant text in the subheading. Keep in mind that readers will be skimming the subheadings for relevant terms and need to see them clearly, so when using proper names, use abbreviated forms: last names for persons, and initialisms/acronyms (if used in the text) for organizations.

Sub-subheadings should be avoided, and only used where absolutely necessary. If these seem to be proliferating, it is usually time to make the affected subheadings into their own headings, with the sub-subheadings now subheadings. A notable exception of the sub-subheading guideline is biographies, where extensive subheadings under the subject – and any other persons extensively referred to – are conventional. These subheadings are often divided into paragraphs, with a one- or two-word heading describing the content: childhood, education, career, later life, personal relationships, and so on. Each paragraph should begin on a separate line, indented under the heading for the person, and the subheadings run-on (see 'Formatting' below). Essentially, these paragraph headings form subheadings, and their related subheadings become sub-subheadings. Details about indexing biographies are beyond the scope of these guidelines; indexers should consult the indexes to published biographies.

FORMATTING

Basic Formats

For clarity, indexes should usually be formatted in the indented (set-out) style, with subheadings and sub-subheadings indented underneath the main entry heading.

Example:

Greece
Byron and 102–3, 106
in *The Last Man* 152
literature 56, 64, 83
in *The Vampyre* 118

However, we can also accept indexes supplied in the run-on style (which is more prevalent in certain disciplines), though this requires careful implementation as it can easily become quite confusing. Sub-subheadings cannot be used with run-on style, where they may be confused with following subheadings.

Example:

Greece: Byron and, 102–3, 106; in *The Last Man*, 152; literature, 56, 64, 83; in *The Vampyre*, 118

Conjunctions

Avoid using words like ‘and’, ‘of’, ‘in’ in sub-headings. If they are to be used for clarity, or as part of a proper noun or title, they should not be factored in to the alphabetical sequence (which should be determined by the first main word).

Example:

aid
local control 12
and local costs 98
machinery 16
and multi-colour projects 50

Cross-references

‘See’ references refer the reader from an unused, relevant term to the one that is used. ‘See also’ references link used, related terms. ‘See under’ references direct the reader to relevant subentries under another heading. ‘See also’ references may also be of the generic type (**Example:** *See also names of particular individuals*).

Separate cross-references from the preceding text by using a comma, semicolon or full point (applied with consistency). If following a full point, the reference should begin with a capital letter (**Example:** aid. *See* foreign aid). Cross-references from subheadings should be in parentheses following the subheading, with the leading text (*see, see also* etc.) lower-cased.

Example:

aid
local control 12 (*see also* NGOs)

GENERAL STYLE POINTS

Spelling, punctuation, capitalization and hyphenation should conform to the style used in the main text of the book. The initial letter of topical headings should be entered lower-case, to distinguish them from proper names and titles beginning with upper-case.

Names

Always ensure that given names or initials are included (a title or rank such as Sir, Colonel, Dr is not sufficient). Conversely, it is acceptable (where useful) to include information which may not be in the text (**Example:** Churchill, (Sir) W. S. (1892–1965), Prime Minister (1940–5, 1951–2)).

Acronyms

Acronyms like UNESCO or DfES should normally be indexed under the full form, spelt out. The abbreviation can be included in parentheses after the entry, or better still, the acronym can be indexed separately and include a cross-reference (**Example:** UN, *see* United Nations).

Follow the general style of the book; do not use full points in abbreviations, unless this follows the style of the book.

Alphabetization

Methods used are either letter-by-letter or word-by-word. Each of these systems has its advantages and disadvantages. The differences between the two mostly affect large indexes comprising an array of concepts, personal, corporate and place names, and titles. Usually, book indexes are unaffected. Bloomsbury favours the letter-by-letter system; however, we can also accept the word-by-word system, provided it is adhered to consistently.

Example:

Letter-by-letter	Word-by-word
Dean, Tacita	de Bretteville, Sheila
de Bretteville, Sheila	De Maria, Walter
<i>Decadent, Public Art</i> (Harding and Buchler)	de Menil, Philippa
DeGeneres, Ellen	Dean, Tacita
Dell 'Arte	<i>Deep Gradient / Suspect Terrain</i> (Roloff)
De Maria, Walter	DeGeneres, Ellen
dematerialization	Dell 'Arte
de Menil, Philippa	dematerialization

Index Mc..., MacK..., Mackenz... etc. under 'Ma', regardless of the varying forms (likewise Saint, St).

Numerals

Isolated headings and subheadings beginning with numerals are filed alphabetically by the first letter of the numeral as spelt-out; '1984 (Orwell)' would be filed under 'n'. Similarly, '9/11' is best filed as 'nine eleven'. When more numerous, they can be listed together at the beginning of the index, before the As.

When two or more similar headings or subheadings with numerals occur together, they are ordered numerically.

Example:

Henry III 12
Henry IV 34, 56
Henry VIII 78, 90

Numbering

Elision of Numbers

Page numbers should be elided as far as possible with an en-dash, i.e. 133–5, 200–1; however, teens should retain the additional ‘1’, i.e. 413–14.

Notes

Where notes have been indexed, use the style ‘129 n.1’ (129 being the page on which the note text appears). Where chapter or book endnotes are used instead of footnotes, please use the page on which the text of the note appears, not the page on which the note marker does. Notes should not be left unnumbered, as there may be several notes on that page.